

| 1989 | ERNET IS INTRODUCED IN INDIA

Weave the People

India had a limited network even as the world was discovering the Web

Years before BlackBerrys and Apples got embedded into cyberspace, premier national labs like the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) in Bangalore and the iconic IITs were already playing father to motherboards and yanking RAMS down Silicon Valley. Refrigerator-sized computers greeted our tech pioneers as early as 1989 even as mathematician Tim Berners-Lee was scribbling away his revolutionary idea to weave a World Wide Web. It was only in March 1989 that he succeeded in his mission while working at the particle physics lab in Geneva, popular through its French acronym CERN. However, a month before Berners-Lee's Big Bang idea shrunk the global village, the IISc and IITs were already cruising on the information superhighway via the Educational and Research Network (ERNET). While technocrats like S. Ramakrishnan, operating through their Delhi offices, steered the ERNET providing early Internet links to the country, another pioneer N. Seshagiri headed the National Informatics Centre, Delhi, that spun a tech orb around the country in 1975. Ornithologist M.B. Krishna, a research scholar at IISc in those days, began learning new meanings to old words like the net (not just a cotton fabric), web (not silk alone) or mouse (nothing to do with rats). He is currently working in the area of ecology and environment management. However, it was only in the 1990s that the Central government allowed and enabled the Web to spin across to the general population through its telecom departments. VSNL became the first service provider in 1995, followed by others, who now connect about 100 million users. India has around six million broadband connections, making it the fastest growing sector. Despite an early start, India is yet to build a robust national network for the Web world. But for a country that is home to globally known IT icons like Infosys, TCS and Wipro, the Web has not enveloped the entire nation like in the West. But as N. Balakrishnan, an IISc professor, puts it, "We were already there, in sync with the developments that were taking place in the European labs, even in the 1980s and 90s."

by Stephen David



SAURABH SINGH - www.indiatodayimages.com



NUSLI WADIA TOOK ON THE AMBANIS

THE MAIN EVENT

Ambani-Wadia War

The protagonists are a study in contrasts. On one side, Dhirubhai Ambani, a street-smart operator whose rags-to-riches story has rewritten corporate history and radically changed the rules of the market-place. And ranged against him, Nusli Wadia, a suave, sophisticated tycoon descended from centuries of empire builders. The contrast does not end here. Ambani presides over the fastest-growing industrial group in the country with assets of Rs 3,875 crore. Wadia is chairman of Bombay Dyeing with assets of just Rs 259 crore. Despite that, their battle has become one of the fiercest and most personalised in Indian corporate history, involving not just business rivalry but also the most powerful personages in the country. But now, even by their extreme standards, what is unfolding is, possibly the bloodiest chapter in the cut-throat war.

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ALSO

- The 8th Asian Championships in Athletics are held in Delhi
- A minority government is formed under the leadership of V.P. Singh
- India's first intermediate range ballistic missile Agni is launched

M.F. Husain He consistently raised the price of art works in India and was a big draw globally.

Tata-Corus Deal The takeover of the Anglo-Dutch steelmaker in 2006 made Tata the 5th largest steel group.

Abhinav Bindra The sharpshooter from Mohali put India on the global map with a gold at the 2008 Olympics.

Chandrayaan India's first unmanned lunar probe brought its space programme global accolades in 2008.

Slumdog Millionaire With three Oscars to two bonafide Indian citizens, it captured the attention of the world.